CAREER EXPLORATION RESOURCES

Free tools to help you explore, compare, and choose a career.
Ask staff at the Resource Room desk for help with any of these tools.

RESOURCE	WHAT IT'S FOR
CA Career Zone cacareerzone.org	Take free assessments (interests, motivations, budget), then filter jobs to your matches. Shows CA salary and job growth. Soon to be retired.
California Career Surfer calcareercenter.org/informational/careerssurferapp (mobile app)	Explore 900+ occupations from your phone. Includes a quick interest inventory — good option if you don't have computer access.
My Next Move mynextmove.org	Take a 5-10 minute interest assessment, then search or browse careers by keyword, industry, or job zone.
Local Job Projections www.tinyurl.com/california-projections	Provides local job and industry projections. Filter by education required, occupation, industry, and geographic area.
O*Net Job Explorer onetonline.org	The most detailed source for researching one specific job with the most information about what it entails and how to be competitive.
O*Net Green/Conservation Topics onetonline.org/search/green_topics	Browse 72 conservation ("green") career categories if you're interested in environmental work.
Greater Sac Area Pathway Profiles www.coeccc.net/region/greater-sacramento	Choose a sector profile to explore local job demands, wages, and key skills recruiters are looking for.

Career Exploration Terms

Understanding these keywords will help as you use the tools mentioned above.

- **Job Zone (1–5):** How much education/training/experience a job typically needs. 1 = little to none (HS diploma); 5 = extensive (graduate degree). A higher zone doesn't always mean higher pay — some Job Zone 3 jobs out-earn Job Zone 5 jobs.
- **Career Cluster:** A group of occupations that use similar skills (e.g., Health Sciences, IT, Manufacturing). Useful for finding related jobs if you want to keep your options open.
- **RIASEC:** A 6-category interest assessment (Realistic, Investigative, Artistic, Social, Enterprising, Conventional). Your top 3 letters are your "code," used to match you to compatible occupations.
- **Questions?** Ask your Resource & Referral Coordinator.

TIPS & GUIDANCE: CHOOSING OR CHANGING A CAREER

5 Steps to Choosing a Career

1. **Clarify your goals:** Allow yourself to dream first. Think about lifestyle, family, travel, health, and finances — these all affect the salary and location you'll need.
2. **Identify your resources:** Personal strengths, financial support, local training programs, and your target "job zone" (how much education/training you're willing to invest).
3. **Explore interests & occupations:** Use CA Career Explorer, O*Net, or My Next Move to match your interests, values, and income needs to real jobs.
4. **Narrow down options:** Keep a simple spreadsheet of jobs you're considering, including ones you ruled out and why. Pick your top 3 and compare cost vs. benefit.
5. **Make a realistic plan — and stick to it:** Be realistic, stay motivated, and check in with a case manager or professional if the plan isn't working.

WORKSHEET: Career Needs & Exploration

Use these questions before you start exploring specific occupations

Part 1 – Prepare for exploration

Explore both your needs and your wants; the minimum you require, and what you want out of life and a career.

What income will you require?

Think of the minimum you will need to cover living expenses, as well as what's needed for you to achieve your life goals.

- **Consider** where you plan to live, your family size/dependents, and transportation needs.
- **Try these budget tools:** www.calculator.net/budget-calculator.html, www.freebudget.org, or mobile apps - such as Empower, WalletHub, or Google Doc budget templates.

Basic Minimum **Yearly** Salary: $_____ Dream Minimum **Yearly** Salary: $_____

Basic Minimum **Hourly** Wage: $_____ Dream Minimum **Hourly** Wage: $_____

What do you realistically need from a job to maintain your physical and mental health?

Consider: Health benefits Paid time off Self-care needs Physical restrictions Schedule type

_____

_____

_____

What would make a career enjoyable and fulfilling for you – other than income?

Consider your passions, interests, tasks you like doing, the impact you want to have on the world, and what would make a career enjoyable and rewarding for you.

_____

_____

_____

What kind of career preparation are you able to invest or what is your current Job Zone? _____

Part 2 – Explore Careers

For each career that you are interested in: Find the information below to learn if it meets your needs, is something you want to do, and is a good investment. Use tools like CA Career Zone, O*Net, and state and local job projections to find this information.

Occupation Title	Interest Level 0 - 5	Local Hourly Wage/Salary	*The % of growth/decline in # of jobs added.* Local Projections	State Projections	Additional Training/Education Required	Good Match? *Circle One*
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No
						Yes / No